

IFS WITH CHILDREN AND ADOLESCENTS

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DOI: 10.4324/9780203126691-3

In working with children and adolescents who are dependent on their families, the internal family systems (IFS) therapist must consider how this vulnerable population is embedded in an external as well as internal family system. This chapter illustrates ways in which parts of children get injured in relationships and become burdened; how those polarizations in the external family can impact the child's injured parts and seriously impinge on the child's capacity for Self-leadership; and how healing the external family helps facilitate the child's internal healing. Finally, I discuss some specific clinical techniques for using IFS with very young children and adolescents.

BASIC ASSUMPTIONS OF THE IFS MODEL

IFS posits that the natural state of human beings is to be subdivided into parts. It maintains that everyone is born with a Self who contains desirable qualities such as calmness, curiosity and compassion as well as perseverance and patience. IFS assumes that we are born with this Self-energy as well as with parts and the ability to produce more parts, and asserts that internal balance and harmony are fostered as parts develop a relationship with, and act as a resource for, the Self.

As burdens are transmitted from adults to children, the child's Self-leadership is blocked. When vulnerable, wounded parts of the child are pushed into exile, protective parts who are searching for solutions often become polarized. For example, one part may urge compliance whereas another urges rebellion. And, as protectors jostle for influence in the internal system, they tend to become more extreme.

HOW CHILDREN ARE BURDENED

When a child feels ignored, dismissed, embarrassed, humiliated, terrified or ashamed and develops the belief that she is unloved, unlovable or worthless she can develop what IFS calls a burden. Parts acquire burdens due to attachment disruptions that range from milder traumas (illustrated later) to neglect, physical and sexual abuse, the extremes of interpersonal trauma.

Beliefs about self-worth and lovability that children develop in extreme types of abuse can be predictable and straightforward. Protectors will exile the parts who hold these beliefs to minimize the child's vulnerability. But more subtle and elusive avenues of burdening are equally important to understand when working with children. Let's take the example of a 2-year-old who is running along a sidewalk and falls, scraping his knee. He gets up, looks at his knee, sees blood and cries. He has ventured into the world and been injured. His parts will look for a Self-led response of welcome for his feelings and permission to feel them for as long as he needs, signaling that both he and his feelings are acceptable. This response will comfort and reassure. If, however, he is told, "Boys don't cry, brush it off, you're fine," he will begin to see that this feeling and his behavior are unacceptable.

Clearly, he has run into a part of his parent who does not welcome his fear and sadness and literally advises him to brush off the tearful part. Some parts of the child may feel hurt by the parent's rebuke whereas others feel angry. However, parts seeking to protect the child's connection with the parent may pursue various options for suppressing his feelings, reasoning, "If he doesn't cry, he won't be criticized and he won't feel this pain and anger. I'll never let him cry again," and/or "I'll tell him that he's bad for being angry so he won't make dad angry."

Or suppose a parent were to respond by scooping up the child and exclaiming, "Are you OK? Please don't cry, don't cry! Don't let go of my hand again." This more attentive response still teaches the child that his tearfulness is unwelcome and once again he is offered no real comfort. Instead he might feel wrong for having run ahead alone or for crying. His parts could decide, "He should never let go of mom's hand again because if he's safe, he won't feel scared and cry, and then he won't feel wrong."

In sum, although it may be easier to understand that a parent's angry, critical, judging parts create burdens, caretaking parts with an agenda of soothing parental anxiety can also produce burdens. When any part blends it eliminates Self-leadership. I'll call this being parts-led rather than Self-led. Parenting that is parts-led inevitably burdens. The degree of burdening is dependent on the agendas of the parent's parts, how extreme they get and to what degree they are polarized with the child's parts.

POLARIZATIONS

The parent/child system is not one of equality. Adults have more power and more choices. A dependent child relies on her parents for food, shelter, clothing, education and nurturing. Children are almost universally powerless to change the nature of their relationships with their parents without some support

from a parent. The child can only attempt to drive change in the external family system indirectly and symptomatically, and this is notoriously ineffective. Change comes when those who hold power in the family shift behavior, allowing less powerful family members to shift as well. Children must look to their parents and other important adults (caretakers, relatives, teachers) to gain a sense of identity and be loved. In the course of parts-led parenting they also discover what will not be accepted. This can be a sorrowful shock to a child but it will also become part of her reality—a problem that requires immediate internal attention and problem solving. Symptoms are markers for that internal problem-solving process.

In a perfect world, children would have Self-led caregivers who would welcome all of their parts with compassion, loving all equally, allowing the child's Self to emerge so that she would grow into a Self-led adult. However real parents are, almost inevitably, somewhat or totally parts led. IFS theory asserts that how we react to our own parts will govern how we react to similar parts in other people: parts who have been exiled by our protectors will be equally unacceptable in other people.

For example, suppose I have a clingy, needy exile who wants to be cared for by others and a protector who feels irritated with it and, believing it's too much and will drive people away, tells it to grow up. This intolerant protector will react to all needy, dependent parts the same way, whether it is mine or someone else's. If I have children this protector will also be intolerant of my child's needy, clinging part. Given this chain of negative influence, attending to parent/child polarizations must be a major focus of IFS therapy. Polarizations are addressed in two ways: first by helping the parents identify and lessen the impact of their own parts and, second, by helping the child to unburden his parts. Because parents have more power, they authorize change in family relationships when they are willing to heal their own parts. When parental unburdening occurs, the parent's protectors relax both internally and externally with the child's parts. As the child has less to defend against from the outside, her protectors are more likely step back and allow exiles to be healed. Therefore, the best therapeutic results are achieved when parents attend to their own burdened parts and become more Self-led.

When parents will not actively engage in therapy it is likely that parts of the parent/child system will continue to be polarized. In this case, the child will feel less safe, her protectors must continue to defend, and she may be in too much pain for the therapy to access exiles, all of which hinders unburdening. For these children, the therapy will focus on facilitating relationships between the child's Self and her protective parts. In the course of developing a relationship with the Self, protectors unblend and Self-energy is released. More Self-energy facilitates stability and calm. Therefore working with protectors can be highly effective and is worthwhile even when access to exiles is limited.

COMMON POLARIZATIONS BETWEEN PARENTS AND CHILDREN

Polarizations typically occur between parent and child in a number of ways. A parent's manager(s) or firefighter(s) can become polarized with a child's exile(s). For example, an adult has a manager who does not want to "spoil" a baby by picking it up when it cries; or an adult has a firefighter who gets

irritated or angry when the child needs help or clings. Or a parent’s exile(s) and a child’s manager(s) or firefighter(s) can become polarized. For example, a parent has an exile who feels worthless when her child becomes more independent, or a parent has an exile who feels unloved when his child’s firefighter gets angry and lashes out.

A parent’s firefighter(s) and a child’s managers can get polarized. For example, an adolescent’s manager throws out all the alcohol so that his alcohol-dependent mother cannot drink, or a child’s manager tries to make her behave “perfectly” in an attempt to keep her father from becoming rageful. We also see polarizations between a parent’s manager(s) and a child’s firefighter(s). This is especially common during adolescence when firefighters can step up with force. Common adolescent firefighter behaviors include excessive body piercing and tattooing; unconventional hair colors and styles; impulsive anger; risk-taking behaviors such as fast driving, hazardous sports and perilous sexual activity; eating disorders and use of alcohol and drugs. An example of a polarization between a parent’s manager(s) and a child’s firefighter(s) would be a parent forbidding an adolescent girl from dating for fear that she would become sexually active.

DIRECT ACCESS AND INSIGHT

The techniques called direct access and insight are the foundation of IFS therapy with both children and adults. When the therapist uses direct access she centers in Self-energy and then speaks directly to one or more parts of the client. This is not a conversation between a part of the therapist and a part of the client; rather it is a Self-to-part relationship. Insight also involves the Self-to-part relationship but the relationship is between the Self of the client and a part of the client. When using insight we guide the client to “go inside” and get to know parts. Both modalities, then, require a Self-to-part relationship, one between the Self of the therapist and a part of the client (direct access) and one between the Self and a part of the client (insight). In either Self-to-part relationship, Self-energy, that feeling state that lies along the continuum from curiosity to compassion, is available to the client’s parts. [Table 3.1](#) illustrates the difference between insight and direct access.

Table 3.1 Accessing Parts in Therapy

Insight	Client’s parts	Client’s Self	Therapist’s Self
Direct access	Client’s parts		Therapist’s Self
A problem	Client’s parts	Therapist’s parts	No Self

For those children who can use insight, IFS therapy looks much the same as it does for older adolescents and adults. However, a significant number of children have difficulty going inside. For them, the therapist can gain all the benefits of insight with the following externalizing techniques.

INSIGHT AND EXTERNALIZING PARTS

In some children, parts are externalized (and therefore unblended) naturally in play. For other children, the therapist will want to facilitate unblending with externalization. Once parts unblend, the therapist can engage the child with insight. Two examples follow: the first illustrates natural unblending during play; the second illustrates how parts can be externalized to facilitate unblending.

PARTS WHO ARE NATURALLY EXTERNALIZED IN PLAY

The child whose parts are naturally externalized into objects will engage with those objects as motivated beings. For example, she might pick up two dolls and have the dolls converse. In IFS we think of each doll as a part. Here is a case example. Ellie came to me at age 7 years because of her “uncontrollable” anger. Ellie’s parents were divorced and she lived with her mother and siblings but stayed with her biological father every other weekend. Ellie’s biological father had some intimidating parts whose anger was often directed at Ellie. In consequence she was angry in both homes and in school and because her peers were afraid of her, she had no friends. Ellie loved to play with figures in my office, especially a brown horse and a velociraptor (raptor). The raptor was angry and aggressive and dominated the horse. It would knock the horse over, jump up and down on it and refuse to let it speak.

I asked the raptor, “What are you afraid would happen if you let the horse stand up and talk?”

It replied, “The horse is so weak it gets hurt. I have to keep it down and quiet so it’s safe.”

In other words, the raptor was a protector trying to keep the horse (an exile) from being hurt again. Over the next several sessions I continued to talk with the raptor and heard that the raptor was actually sad. It did not want to be angry but felt that no one else was keeping Ellie and the brown horse safe when she visited her father.

The raptor explained, “When Ellie’s father yells at her, the brown horse gets scared and feels like no one is going to help and no one loves her. This is how I have to protect the brown horse.”

Once the raptor revealed more of its purpose, I asked Ellie how she felt toward the raptor. This fundamental question in the IFS model reveals how much Self-energy is available.

Ellie said, “I like the raptor. I know what it wants to do.” Her answer showed me that she now had access to Self-energy so I could begin to facilitate the relationship between Ellie’s Self and her parts with the eventual goal of the horse releasing her burdens.

During the next several sessions Ellie listened to the raptor talk about what made it angry. Some of the events were current and some were in the past. As the raptor felt more understood and less criticized we told it that Ellie herself could help the horse not be as vulnerable to feeling hurt. However, to do that we needed the raptor to step back and let us talk directly with the horse. When we promised to make sure the horse was safely tucked away before we ended each session, the raptor agreed to let the horse talk.

As Ellie developed a relationship with the raptor both her mother and teacher reported Ellie was less angry. I asked Ellie if she noticed the change in her behavior; she confirmed she had not felt so angry lately. We were both curious about the reason for the difference and Ellie suggested we ask the raptor.

When asked, the raptor replied, “Before I met you everybody told me I was bad and yelled at me all the time. Nobody liked me. But you like me and want to help me and that makes me feel better.”

It is important to note that Ellie’s behavior began to change as soon as Ellie’s Self developed a relationship with the protector (raptor) even though she had not witnessed or unburdened her exile (the horse). This illustrates the importance of the Self-to-part relationship with protectors and how changes can begin early in the therapeutic process.

Subsequently, Ellie developed a relationship with the horse in the same way she had with the raptor. As Ellie witnessed and unburdened the horse her anger regulated in most environments. But the raptor continued to feel unsafe with Ellie’s father and so continued to be more active when Ellie was visiting him. Nevertheless, even with Ellie’s father the raptor was less angry and reactive than it had been before she witnessed and unburdened the horse.

INVITING PARTS TO EXTERNALIZE

When a child’s parts do not naturally unblend, the therapist can invite the child to choose an object that represents his feeling state. For example, when a child arrives at a session visibly feeling an emotion such as anger, sadness, or anxiety the therapist can ask her to let that feeling pick an object to represent itself. Parts can be externalized in this way into a wide variety of objects, including puppets, dolls, drawings, stones, seashells and clay. Feel free to use whatever mode or object is most comfortable for the child and you. In the following example Simon used animal figures.

Simon entered therapy with me at the age of 9 years because he was breaking things in his bedroom during episodes of anger. Before starting with Simon, I met with his parents to discuss their concerns and hopes. I introduced them to IFS and explained that I would initially meet separately with Simon and with them but eventually we would have family sessions. In my first session with Simon, I introduced myself and invited him to explore my office. In general, the early stages of IFS play therapy are nondirective so that the child can become comfortable and feel safe. I told Simon that he was free to talk with me or not, and to play with any toys and games or not.

Initially, Simon was agreeable and easy going. He liked to play games and often brought his own game to our sessions and showed little affect whether he won or lost. During this phase of treatment I saw only this part of Simon. There was no sign of the angry part who continued to rail at home. Naturally, Simon’s parents were concerned that he was not “dealing with” his anger. I assured them that the anger would emerge when he felt comfortable enough with me. As an IFS therapist I know that parts emerge when they feel safe and, indeed, several weeks into our work Simon’s behavior changed, indicating that other parts were emerging. He was now reluctant to leave his mother’s car to come into my office. I encouraged his parents to continue bringing him.

Now Simon began to get angry about coming to our sessions. His mother frequently had to take his hand and lead him to my office and once even carried him in. I helped her work with her parts to stay calm and determined when she brought Simon. Now he refused to play when he met with me. He sometimes sat in silence and other times spoke loudly and angrily about how much he hated therapy. During these sessions, I remained curious about Simon and welcoming of his anger. I asked Simon, “Are you interested in knowing more about your anger since it gets you in trouble at home?”

The first four times I made this invitation Simon refused. However, the fifth time he said, “Yes, I would like to know my anger because I hate feeling angry all the time!” Simon loved animals so I asked him to pick one of the animals on my shelf to be his anger. He chose a large gorilla and put it on my table. To begin the unblending process, I asked Simon, “How do you feel toward the gorilla?” In my mind, the gorilla was, of course, a part.

He said, “I hate it.”

Clearly this was another part speaking and I knew that the gorilla could not reveal itself as long as this highly critical part was blended with Simon.

So I said, “Can you find an animal who looks like this feeling of ‘hate’ toward the gorilla and put it on the table too?”

He selected a black panther and placed it face-to-face with the gorilla. When I asked if he wanted to know more about the gorilla and the panther, Simon said, “Yes.” This curiosity indicated Simon had some Self-energy.

I said, “Why don’t you ask them what they want to say to each other?”

Simon explained, “The panther doesn’t like the gorilla because it gets him in so much trouble. The panther says Simon’s mother, father and sister are always angry or afraid of him and don’t want to be around him.”

I said to Simon, “Ask the panther what is so bad about people not wanting to be around him?”

The panther replied, “Then Simon feels empty and alone. If he could just be a little nicer and do what people want him to then everyone would like him and he would feel better. But,” the panther added sadly, “even though I’ve tried and tried to get the gorilla to stop being so angry he never listens.”

I asked, “How do you feel toward the panther now?”

Simon said, “I feel sad for him. He’s doing his best.”

I asked Simon to tell this to the panther, who listened and felt reassured. Then I said, “Shall we offer the panther some hope by saying that we can talk with the gorilla and find out what makes him so angry? Once we know why, we can heal the gorilla. All we need is for the panther to move aside so that we can talk to the gorilla directly.” The panther agreed and Simon moved the panther to the far edge of the table.

Then Simon turned his attention to the gorilla. This time when I asked Simon how he felt toward the gorilla, he responded, “I want to get to know it.” I invited Simon to ask the gorilla what it wanted Simon to know about himself.

The gorilla told Simon, “I am trying to help you, not get you in trouble. I want you to feel strong and have people listen to you because no one ever does. No one ever asks what you want, they just tell you what to do.”

We asked the gorilla what was so bad about not being asked and he replied, “Then Simon feels like he’s invisible and no one cares about him. He feels like he has nothing inside. He hates that. I don’t like having to get so angry but I don’t know any other way to help Simon feel strong.”

Simon listened and then said, “I understand. I feel sad that the gorilla has to get angry for me.”

“How about if we find and heal the part in you who feels weak and invisible?” I asked. Simon repeated this question to the gorilla, who agreed that if Simon could do this it would not need to get so angry.

And so Simon finally had permission to contact his weak, invisible part. Our work with the panther and gorilla had unfolded over several sessions. We had been careful to allow as much time as they needed to trust Simon’s Self so they would feel confident that he could take care of this most vulnerable part.

With this permission, Simon moved the gorilla to the back of the table and almost immediately began to feel the weak, invisible part. I asked Simon to pick an animal who looked like this feeling and he selected a wolf whose head was raised in a howl. He placed the howling wolf on the table in front of him.

“How do you feel toward the wolf?” I asked.

“I feel kinda mad at him,” Simon said.

“Is it the gorilla who’s mad?” I asked.

“Yeah,” Simon nodded. “He doesn’t like when the wolf feels this way.” Simon picked up the gorilla and looked it in the eye. He said, “It’s OK. The wolf won’t hurt me.” Simon listened to the gorilla for a moment and then placed him at the back of the table again. “He says he’ll watch,” Simon reported.

“How do you feel toward the wolf now?” I asked.

“I want to know more,” Simon said.

“What’s going on?” I asked.

“I feel smaller,” Simon reported.

When a part begins to blend like this, I do not want it to blend fully and overwhelm the client. My goal is to maintain enough of the Self-to-part relationship that the Self is still the part’s witness. So I said to the wolf, “If you take Simon over, he won’t be there to help you feel better. It’s good to show him what you feel but check to be sure he’s still with you.”

Because parts long for help, they generally agree to this invitation, as the wolf did. And Simon immediately began to have memories of feeling invisible, including the day his younger sister was born. He saw images of his mother attending to the baby and not him, and then images of times in kindergarten and elementary school when he felt unheard or unimportant. He told me what he was remembering and said he was feeling sad, lonely, scared, unlovable and worthless.

“I have a pit in my stomach,” he said. “It feels empty.”

“How do you feel toward the wolf?” I asked, monitoring his Self-to-part relationship. Simon remained loving toward the wolf so I knew he had plenty of Self-energy. After about 5 minutes the memories, feelings and body sensations ceased and a visible calm settled on Simon.

“Ask the wolf if there is anything more it wants to show,” I said.

“He says there’s no more,” Simon replied.

“How do you feel toward the wolf now?” I asked. Simon still felt loving, so I went on, “Ask if he felt understood.”

“He says he hears me talking but he isn’t sure he feels understood.”

On further questioning we discovered that the wolf could not feel Simon’s love because he had been pushed into Simon’s right heel by the panther and gorilla, who both wanted the wolf as far away from Simon’s heart as possible to protect Simon from his pain. I knew the wolf had to feel understood before he could unburden. To feel understood he needed to feel Simon’s love, but even when Simon told the wolf he loved him the wolf did not feel the love.

Wondering how Simon might help the wolf to feel his love, I remembered that touch can increase a feeling of connection. “Ask the wolf if you can touch him,” I said. The wolf was amenable and I invited Simon to put his hands around the wolf and imagine love flowing from his hands into the wolf. Still the wolf could not feel Simon’s love and said that he lived too far from Simon’s heart.

Then it occurred to me that Simon needed to touch the actual spot on his body where the wolf lived. The wolf liked this idea and Simon put one hand on his heart and one on his heel. I said, “Imagine your love traveling from your heart into this hand first, then through your body and into the other hand, and then into the wolf.” As Simon did this the wolf instantly felt calmer. After several minutes I said, “Would you like to ask if the wolf wants to come closer to your heart?” The wolf agreed and moved into the left side of Simon’s torso, retrieved at last from exile. Then I suggested, “Simon, why don’t you move your hand to the spot on your left side where the wolf lives now.”

“I’m sending my love from my heart to the wolf over here,” he said, holding one hand on his heart and one on his left side. He continued doing this with his eyes closed for several minutes until the wolf said he could feel Simon’s love and finally felt understood.

Once this part felt understood, we could begin the unburdening process. I instructed Simon to tell the wolf that he could let go of the painful thoughts, feelings and beliefs he had shown Simon. The wolf told Simon that his burden was in his howl but he could or would not be specific about the burden. This is common in children and, as with adults, it is not necessary to know the exact nature of a burden. We offered the wolf the option of releasing his burden to one of the elements (earth, wind, water, light or air) but he wanted to release the burden into Simon’s heart. After several minutes the wolf indicated he had done so and no longer felt empty or alone.

At my instruction, once the burden was released, Simon asked the wolf what he wanted to invite into himself now that there was more space.

The wolf replied, “Love.”

Because Simon’s hands were still on his heart and torso, I said, “Does the wolf want the love to come from your heart?”

Simon listened and then nodded. We sat quietly for several more minutes as Simon imagined the love flowing from his heart into the wolf in his torso. When we asked the wolf how he was now, he told Simon that he felt loved and lovable.

Before Simon left the office that day we began the integration process, which continued for several weeks. We knew that the gorilla and panther were closely tied to the wolf, so first I had Simon ask if

either of them had any concerns about what had happened with the wolf and neither did. In fact, though they were not sure why, both felt relieved. Because we were nearly at the end of the session I had Simon ask if we could check back with them during our next session to see how they were doing. Both agreed.

The next week Simon said, “The wolf feels better. But he’s still worried that I might forget him and let the gorilla and the panther send him back to my heel.”

“What does the wolf need?” I asked.

Simon asked the wolf, who reminded him that he had the exact same wolf figure at home. The wolf wanted Simon to find that figure and carry it around with him in his book bag. That way the wolf could be with Simon whenever he needed to be. We asked the wolf to designate a signal for when he needed Simon’s attention and he offered to show himself as a small stitch in Simon’s side.

For the next few weeks Simon took the wolf in his book bag wherever he went. When he felt the stitch in his side, he would remove the wolf and hold him. When it was awkward to take the wolf out Simon would silently let the wolf know he would hold him as soon as he was able. Although Simon could still get angry, the feeling was less extreme and more appropriate to the triggering incident. After unburdening the wolf, Simon never had a destructive episode again.

BLENDED PARTS AND DIRECT ACCESS

Some children have parts who will not unblend either naturally in play or when invited. This tells me that one part is in control and the child’s every thought and action is a thought or action of that part. As with adults, when parts are blended and will not unblend, direct access is the modality of choice. In direct access the therapist is the source of Self-energy and to fulfill this role she must be able to unblend her own parts. Here are two clinical examples of direct access.

Jason’s parents brought him to therapy because “he has no friends.” Jason was easily provoked and hit or pushed other children frequently so no one wanted to play with him. His father also complained that Jason was a “cheater” and said, “No one likes a cheater.” Jason was 6 years old.

On his first visit, Jason decided to play the board game Sorry. As we played, I was aware of a series of parts who blended with Jason. While winning Jason was excited and enthusiastic, gloating and telling me that I was a loser. But when the tide turned and I started winning, Jason grew quiet, withdrawn and spoke of feeling hopeless. He said, “I always lose” and “I’ll never catch up to you.” Finally, when it looked like I was going to win the game, Jason swept all the pieces off the board and declared he was quitting. Then he seemed embarrassed and quickly picked up all the pieces, putting them in the box.

During this time I observed a series of my own parts too. At first, I noticed a part who was sad about losing and did not want to play, especially after Jason called me a loser. Then, I noticed a part who got excited and wanted to gloat when I started to win. Next came a caretaking manager who wanted to reassure Jason’s parts and tell him not to feel sad. Finally, I noticed a part who was scared when Jason swept the pieces from the board.

As I observed my parts I asked them to step back so I could stay curious and open while we played the game. That way Jason’s parts would not be subjected to my reactions and would continue to feel

invited, an unusual if not unique experience for him. Once feeling Self-led, a therapist may choose to be silent and observe the child's parts as they emerge. Early in the direct access process, being silent can help the therapist to gain clarity about the nature of the child's parts and how they have been wounded. In our first session, Jason revealed several parts including a firefighter who gloated; a quiet, withdrawn, hopeless exile; a firefighter who swept the pieces off the board and, finally, a manager who cleaned up.

There is no right way for the therapist to respond when using direct access; the only requirement is for the therapist to unblend her parts and be Self-led. When the therapist is Self-led she can trust her intuition. After observing the child's parts, the therapist could choose to speak for her own parts by saying, "I have a part who feels sad when you call me a loser," or "A part of me doesn't have much fun when you gloat" or "Sometimes a part of me feels bad when I beat you." When speaking for parts there is no judgment about the child's part nor is there any request that the child change his behavior. When a therapist speaks for his/her part it can help the child's part become aware of the unintended impact it has on another person. This simple awareness can help a part begin to alter its behavior.

During this first session I was silent until the end of the game when Jason swept the pieces off the board. Then I reassured him that he could choose to stop the game, and whatever he chose was OK with me. Jason stopped cleaning up and listened but did not respond. After that Jason wanted to play Sorry in every session. Over the next few weeks I began to speak for my own parts by naming not only the ones who felt bad when Jason gloated or called me a loser but also parts who loved to win and got frustrated when I did not. Of course, Jason also had parts who could not tolerate losing. His play revealed two parts who tried to protect him from losing: one cheated and the other quit. In this way I welcomed all his parts and they began to trust me.

Jason's parents both had parts who were polarized with Jason's protectors. They both tried to stop his cheating part, which of course shamed him. However, when it came to Jason's quitting part, his parents had opposite reactions. When Jason tried to quit anything, his father had a part who told him only babies quit and that, to be a grown up, 6-year-old Jason should keep playing. In contrast, Jason's mother had a part who helped him avoid any activity in which he might not excel. As I helped his parents notice their own parts, they began to understand Jason's parts and were better able to moderate their reactions.

At the same time, I invited Jason's cheating part to join our play. My goal was to welcome rather than shame his parts. Just as I had told the quitter that it could quit whenever it wanted, I told Jason he could cheat whenever he wanted. Jason's cheater loved this and began making different rules to ensure that Jason would win. I continued to speak for my parts by saying things like, "It's hard for me to always lose," or "I wish I could have special rules, too."

Meanwhile Jason's parents were allowing him to play this way at home so his protectors felt welcomed there as well. With some Self-led psychoeducation, Jason's parents had come to understand that it is normal for a 6-year-old to have parts who feel sad, hopeless and out-of-control when they lose. They also learned that trying to manage or prevent Jason's uncomfortable feelings actually intensified them. Over time, as the parents grew less polarized with Jason's parts, they allowed him to feel sad and hopeless without trying to manage or suppress his feeling. Jason's father was less critical and his mother did not always try to protect him. They still had reactive parts but their reactions came less frequently and were less intense.

Once Jason's parts felt more welcomed things began to change. Though he could not articulate the reason, Jason was more comfortable with the cheater, the quitter and the one who cleaned up. It is the norm with younger children for change to occur without the child, the therapist or the parents knowing exactly which parts have unburdened. But the change will be evident, as it was in Jason as he became less volatile. Now when Jason played Sorry his cheater rarely needed to cheat and he rarely quit a game. He was actually able to say that he hated losing while continuing to play. Indicating newfound courage, Jason began picking games that were more challenging and required strategy such as checkers and Battleship. And his parents as well as his teacher reported that he was calmer. Although he still had no close friends, he did begin to have play dates with one boy and these were going well. This is an example of direct access early in the therapeutic process but it was only the beginning of Jason's therapy, which continued off and on for several years.

DIRECT ACCESS WITH ABBY

Abby was a 4-year-old girl whose mother described her as "painfully shy." Abby never spoke at preschool and had few friends. I began the therapy with Abby's parents and her teacher who had parts who were polarized with Abby's "shyness" and encouraged her to participate in things that she was afraid of, which intensified her fear. As I became more familiar with Abby's parents it became clear they both had parts who found anger unacceptable.

They had exiled not only their own angry parts but Abby's as well. While the parents entered into IFS couple therapy (with another therapist) and began to explore their parts, I talked with Abby's teacher. In an attempt to help Abby feel less shy, the teacher had created a rule that Abby must say one thing in school every day. But the more the teacher encouraged and required Abby to speak, the quieter Abby grew. I asked her to suspend the rule while Abby and I were working together and she agreed.

In our first session Abby stared out the window. She did not look at or speak to me. I asked her if it was OK for me to sit on the sofa and she nodded. I quietly told her that she was free to do whatever she wanted when we were together, she could talk or play or not, and that I would not try to get her to do anything. Abby did not respond. She stared out the window for the entire session.

The second session Abby again stared out the window and I sat on the couch after asking if that was OK with her. About halfway through the session she said, "You can't make me look at you."

I replied, "I understand and that's fine because you get to decide what happens, not me."

The third session was a repeat of the second except this time Abby said, "You can't make me talk to you."

Again I reassured her that she was in charge.

Finally in the fourth session Abby went straight to the closet where I kept the toys. Cautiously curious, she began to play. I asked if I should stay on the couch or sit on the floor near her and she indicated the couch. And so it went for many sessions: I sat on the couch watching her play with animal figures but she spoke too softly for me to hear. Eventually she asked me to play with her and we started to build forts with blankets and pillows. In this play, a part of Abby always wanted to tell me what to do

and how to build the fort. Her parents started to notice this assertive part at home and (predictable in people with managerial parts who disapprove of anger) described it as “bossy.” The part felt like, and indeed was, the polar opposite of Abby’s shy part. Noting Abby’s polarized shy and assertive parts, I assumed they protected a more vulnerable part.

Polarizations occur naturally in any internal system. In the absence of Self-leadership, protective parts vie for control of the system and cover the options for staying safe with opposite strategies that become more extreme over time. When a child presents with a protective strategy like Abby’s shyness, an IFS therapist expects to meet another protector with an opposing view of how to stay safe. And sure enough Abby’s assertive part had showed up.

While Abby and I continued getting to know her parts, I also helped her parents adjust to her new assertiveness. Gradually the assertive part felt welcomed at home as well as in therapy. As a result, it began to be aggressive in therapy. It needed to hit something and wanted to hit me. I pondered how to invite this part in and convey that while all feelings (and parts) were welcome, it was not OK to intentionally hurt anyone physically, verbally or emotionally.

I listened to my own parts. Some understood the importance of welcoming Abby’s aggressive part, some were afraid of her aggression and wanted to protect me from getting hurt. With this input I discovered how I could be respectful of my parts as well as Abby’s. I told her that I could sit on a chair with three large pillows covering my lower body and legs. Her angry part could then hit me where the pillows covered my body. Abby’s part agreed to these guidelines and for several sessions she hit me. Occasionally, Abby’s hand would stray to my arm and I would remind the part that it was not OK to hit me there. She would immediately return to hitting the pillows.

One day Abby did not want to hit. Instead she asked, “Why do I always have to come to your house to play and you don’t ever come to my house?” My office was in an old home.

“Why would you like me to come to your house?” I asked.

Abby replied, “I want to show you how I play at my house.”

She could be no clearer than that. In addition, her invitation was confident and enthusiastic, an attitude I had not witnessed before in Abby. We talked with her mother and made arrangements for me to go to her house to play. The day I visited was sunny and warm. We played a board game, built a fort in her playroom, jumped on her trampoline, and played wiffle ball. Throughout, Abby exuded confidence, playfulness, humor and enthusiasm.

The next week Abby told me she did not need to visit me anymore and I agreed. She was no longer controlled by her shy, withdrawn part and neither Abby nor her parents were exiling her angry protector. She was talkative with friends at preschool and she had started taking ballet lessons. I am not certain if our work unburdened any exiles but, as I said, this is often the case with young children. Although we can see the results of the therapy, the child cannot verbalize her internal experience so we rarely know exactly if or what parts have unburdened.

ADOLESCENTS

As with younger children, direct access and insight can be used with adolescents. Some younger teens may require the same externalizing techniques described above. Others can use insight in the traditional way. Still others will benefit from direct access. There is no way to determine in advance who will require which modality. The modality for any age client is based on her needs. Nevertheless, I am including this separate section on adolescents. They can be a challenge for clinicians as well as for parents and having special techniques for working with them can make a significant and positive difference in their therapy.

Adolescents are more challenging in part because of the way they produce firefighters, the protectors who react by numbing or suppressing pain after an exile has surfaced. The reactive behavior of firefighters can seem out-of-control and reckless. Common adolescent firefighter behavior includes: drug and alcohol use, sexual promiscuity, rage, extreme clothing and hairstyles, withdrawal, silence, extreme sports, reckless driving, cutting, bingeing and purging, restricting calories, extreme exercise, excessive TV watching or playing video games and suicidal thinking. And this list is by no means exhaustive. Any part seeking to numb pain would be considered a firefighter.

For the managerial parts of adults, these behaviors can be particularly confusing and frightening. What could make a young person behave so illogically? Focusing on the adolescent's search for identity, Ames, Ilg & Baker (1988) wrote,

The search for self is, in some ways, what adolescence is all about— finding oneself, learning to identify, count on, and depend on oneself. And to do this one must get free of one's earlier dependence on and veneration of one's parents ... [a task that requires] much trying on of different personalities. (p. 220)

In the struggle to differentiate and become independent, parts of adolescents frequently adopt new and different behaviors of which parents disapprove. Attempting to protect adolescents, parents, teachers and even therapists try to quell extreme behavior with logic, criticism, anger, punishment, bribery, nagging or worry. Anytime an adult leads from a part rather than from Self, no matter how loving or correct the part may be, a polarization will develop. The blended adult will not have access to curiosity about the teenager's behavior and will automatically be pulled into a polarization with the teenager's firefighter. Once curiosity is lost so is the connection.

With adolescents more than with any other population, therapists must be aware of polarizations. They are common between parts of the adolescent and the parent as well as between parts of the adolescent and the therapist. It also helps if the therapist has a real appreciation for the adolescent's extreme, reactive parts. Every parts-led system needs firefighters because no manager can keep exiles from surfacing 100 percent of the time. Eventually all exiles get triggered and—without firefighters—emotions such as worthlessness, humiliation and terror flood the system. Thus, even if it were possible, it would make no sense to eliminate firefighters. When authorities (including mental health workers) do

manage to shut down one firefighter, another steps up to take its place. The only solution is to get to know firefighters and offer them hope that the exile can be healed. Here is a case example of IFS therapy with an adolescent.

Nan, 19-years-old when we met, was referred to me for treatment of bulimia. Her bingeing and purging began during high school but got worse during her first year of college. She took a leave of absence and was home living with her parents. Beginning in high school, Nan had been in a cognitive-behavioral therapy for bulimia and had been hospitalized briefly. When we started to work together, Nan requested that I meet separately with her and her parents until she had a clearer sense of her Self and her parts.

Though 19 years old by the calendar, Nan's developmental age was closer to 13. Nevertheless, from the beginning she was able to focus internally (that is, to use insight) to communicate with her parts. Very early on we discovered some powerful caretaking and pleasing parts and I noticed an absence of anger in her system. Her pleasing parts were so strong that they kept Nan from ever disagreeing with her parents, no matter how large or small the issue. Nan's parents were loving, kind people who also showed no anger. They both had extreme caretaking parts who wanted Nan to be happy and fulfilled at all times and worked hard to keep her from having "bad" feelings.

Nan began her work by getting to know her pleasing part. This protector told Nan that she felt safe and loved with her parents and was afraid that if Nan disagreed or expressed anger they might not love and keep her safe any longer. I helped Nan listen to and appreciate this protector. As Nan did so, the part grew to trust her and agreed to let us help the scared exile it protected. As the pleasing part stepped back, its polarized opposite, an edgy protector, appeared. The edgy part did not experience Nan's parents as loving but believed they were disinterested in Nan's desires and needs and so she was unheard and unloved. This protector did not want Nan to feel unloved. It believed if she could stand up to her parents and be heard, she would feel loved.

This example illustrates Nan's polarized protectors trying to achieve the goal of feeling loved with opposite tactics. One believes that being pleasing will bring Nan love; the other believes Nan will feel loved when she demands that her parents listen to her. As Nan became more Self-led and formed an appreciative relationship with this assertive part, her internal balance of power shifted and the pleasing part was no longer dominant. As a result Nan could now be terse and even irritable with her parents. Initially this shift troubled her parents so I explained that it was normal for her behavior to change as she developed relationships with her parts and that her irritability would not last forever.

They were also concerned because Nan continued to binge and purge. I explained the IFS view of extreme protectors, which is that bingeing and purging are efforts of a protective part to squelch painful emotion. I warned them that this behavior would wax and wane during treatment and might be more frequent if we were actively working with an exile. I assured them it would drop in frequency and eventually disappear as her internal system was healed.

Because her previous therapy had done little to change the eating disordered behavior, Nan's parents made a decision to trust me and the IFS model. Wanting to be sure that Nan stayed healthy, we all (including Nan) agreed that she would visit her physician every 4 to 8 weeks to monitor her health. In addition, her parents did just enough IFS therapy to ensure they would not become polarized with her emerging parts. As they grew more familiar with their parts and emotions, they stopped reacting to Nan

with the feelings of hurt and anxiety and subsequent withdrawal or smothering her with attention. Eventually they stopped looking through Nan's room for evidence of her disordered eating and that was enough of a shift for Nan's parts to feel less judged. Once this external judgment abated, Nan's irritated, terse part could step back and began allowing her access to the lonely exile who felt unloved.

Nan's case is a good illustration of IFS therapy with adolescents because the stages in which her exiles unburdened were linked to her level of dependence on her parents—certain exiles were not accessible at all until Nan was financially independent. Our work with one important exile began while she was on leave from college. Over several sessions, Nan discovered that this exile felt unloved, unseen and not good enough. It showed Nan scenes of herself being shy and feeling different, unseen, disconnected and inferior. When it felt Nan understood these distressing experiences, it released some of the burden. But it let Nan know that it could not yet show her everything.

After this unburdening, her bingeing and purging stopped and she was calmer with her parents—neither overly compliant nor irritable in her family—and she decided to take a break from therapy. I supported her, but we both knew the exile still had burdens. Nan returned to college and several months later felt the urge to binge and purge. She called and we began regular sessions of phone therapy. This time the exile showed Nan times when she had felt unloved and unheard by her parents. She saw why neither the pleasing nor the angry part had wanted her to view these scenes when she was still dependent on the people who were central to this exile's burden. When the exile felt understood by Nan, it released more of the loneliness, fear and worthlessness but still not all.

Once again Nan stopped bingeing and purging. And now a part who was angry with her parents emerged. Both the pleasing part and the partially unburdened exile were afraid of this angry part. Nan reassured them that the anger would not take her over and that she could help it feel less angry. The exile agreed, but the pleasing part was afraid the anger would do something to rupture Nan's relationship with her parents permanently and insisted that Nan limit contact with her parents while getting to know the anger. Nan agreed and asked me to explain to them why she would be more distant for a time.

Nan spent many sessions with this angry part who showed scenes in which it had felt unloved and unseen. It also showed Nan the ways in which her parents, teachers and other parts had suppressed its anger. Once the part felt understood and welcomed by Nan, it felt less vulnerable and less in need of protection, and began to relax. In response the angry part gave up being so angry and, referring to itself as Nan's "backbone," decided instead to help her be assertive and say "no" proactively.

Once the anger moderated, Nan resumed regular contact with her parents and enjoyed her growing sense of Self-leadership, which she described as a feeling of calm clarity in which she was able to be with her emotion rather than being the emotion. She decided to take another break from therapy and, as before, I supported her. Nan found a job in her field after graduating and was now financially independent from her parents. Several months later she began to binge and purge again so resumed therapy.

Now that Nan was independent, the pleasing and angry protectors were willing to allow the partially unburdened exile to reveal its deepest burdens. The exile reappeared, this time simply as a sense of abject worthlessness and a burning, empty feeling in Nan's stomach. It took several sessions before the part could even notice love coming from Nan's Self. Once it felt her presence it longed to be held and rocked, which Nan did. The part never showed Nan any images but Nan came to understand through its

sensations that it had been burdened early in life. Her parents had been loving but also anxious and eager for Nan to feel good. Longing for a loving heart, this part had gotten loving anxiety instead. Over several weeks as the part felt increasingly connected to Nan and received her love, it released the remaining burden of emptiness and worthlessness.

Nan ended therapy after this and I have not heard from her in several years. There were many parts she did not witness, including the ones who binged and purged. Any time she attempted to help them, a part who felt ashamed of the behaviors would block her access. Because I know that parts will emerge in the best order for their system, I did not push Nan either to witness or avoid these parts. Nevertheless, parts who remain unwitnessed and surrounded by shame are vulnerable to being triggered by life events—at which time I can imagine Nan resuming IFS therapy.

CONCLUSIONS

This chapter illustrates how IFS can be applied to children and adolescents using both insight and direct access. Some young people are able to use insight as adults do; others need their parts externalized into objects. As with most child and family therapies, IFS is most likely to be successful when caretakers also engage in the therapeutic process. Deciding on a case-by-case basis, taking into account the degree to which the parents are Self-led, the therapist may choose to do therapy with the family unit or work with the child separately.

Polarizations between parent and child are particularly important. The therapist will help adults to observe how their parts are polarized with their child's parts, understand their own parts and have compassion for the child's parts. Once parent/child polarizations are relaxed, the child is free to explore her own internal system. And, finally, unburdening can and does happen while children are dependent on their parents but some parts may need the child to be independent before unburdening can be complete.

REFERENCE

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